

“What do you see as the key personal and professional qualities of a teacher of Computing and how might these shape positive classroom relationships. Also, please comment on the qualities you have which would help you form positive and appropriate working relationships with pupils.”

My experience on teaching placement during my BA in Mathematics & Education, as well as teaching with the educational charity Corrib Kids Coding, has helped me identify qualities that have stood out to me over time as being integral in fostering positive educational environments:

Patience, Empathy and Sociocultural Awareness

I feel it's important for the teacher to remember that while they are in charge of the classroom the environment could be considered symbiotic between students and teacher - both the teacher's and the students' cooperation and interactions contribute to the environment of the classroom. In my opinion, the onus is on the teacher to remain patient and empathetic with students in the classroom. To be aware that they might have different home rules, different levels of parental involvement, different difficulties in adapting to the expectations of the classroom in terms of behaviour and work ethic. A teacher should remain patient and encouraging with all students. This outlook has, for example, helped me promote a positive relationships who began working later in the year following persistent encouragement from me.

Lesson Planning, Learning Outcomes and Resource Sharing

In my opinion, the importance of lesson planning cannot be understated in helping alleviate the stresses of teaching. With in-depth and structured lesson planning in place the teacher can be more present and interactive with students in-person throughout the lesson. Knowing the planned flow of the lesson, and how it fits into the GCSE / A-Level syllabi, can help inform the teacher's ability to differentiate instructions and questioning to assist students of all abilities throughout the classroom. I feel it is important to clearly state the expected learning outcomes of the lesson at the beginning, and explain how the topics/activities of the lesson fit into the context of the students' learning this year and the wider context of the examination syllabus. I believe the teacher being aware and sharing this information with students helps foster a positive environment with the context promoting learning. Personally, I feel it's important to share as many resources as I can with my students that are relevant to the topics of the syllabus / working in the computer science industry. This is something that has helped me develop positive relationships with students in the past, and I believe my willingness to share resources increased the students' willingness to speak up in class to ask questions or ask for help.